AS

PRIME MINISTER NARENDRA MODI PREPARED TO ADDRESS THE NATION ON MAY 12, two days after the dramatic cessation of hostilities in India's sixth war with Pakistan, he knew it would be a defining moment of his third term. Twenty-six years earlier, in the summer of 1999, the Indian armed forces had, under the watch of Atal Bihari Vajpayee, the first prime minister of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), successfully repelled Pakistan's brazen bid to capture the Kargil heights in what was the fifth war between the two countries. If circumstances had forced Vajpayee to go to war, then Modi, too, had no option but to visit severe punishment upon its neighbour for fostering a terror infrastructure that was responsible for the brutal gunning down of 26 innocent civilians in Pahalgam, Kashmir, on April 22.

Just two years into his first term (2014-2019), Modi had pivoted away from his predecessor Manmohan Singh's policy of strategic restraint against Pakistan's transgressions towards punitive deterrence. It meant that

The Four-Day War

OPERATION SINDOOR

India's strikes on terror havens in retaliation to the Pahalgam massacre were non-escalatory. But Pakistan responded with attacks on military targets and upped the lethality. Everything it hurled was repulsed. Then, India struck fierce blows at Pakistani air bases



The damage at the Lashkar complex at Muridke after the Indian air strike on May 7

AFP

DAY 1

MAY 7 0100–0130 HRS

- India initiates Operation Sindoor, launching precision strikes on terrorist infrastructure across nine locations in PoK and Pakistan Punjab
- Drones, loitering munitions and Rafale/ MiG 29 jets equipped with precision weapons hit Jaish-e-Mohammed and Lashkar-e-Taiba hubs; 100 reportedly killed. Pakistan claims downing of Indian jets
- Later in the day, Pakistan convenes National Security Council. Cross-border shelling intensifies in Kashmir

2030 HRS

- Pakistani counterattack starts; 15 Indian air bases—including Awantipur, Srinagar, Jammu, Amritsar, Jalandhar, Adampur, Bathinda, Pathankot, Uttarlai and Bhuj—targeted with drones, loitering munitions
- India's air defence (AD) grid neutralises attacks
- India asserts that Pakistani AD targets were hit in retaliation, crucial AD systems in Lahore destroyed through Suppression of Enemy Air Defences (SEAD) operations

DAY 2

MAY 8-9 20:30 HRS–04:30 HRS

- Pakistan opens with short-range surface-to-surface missiles, targets Udhampur and Pathankot air bases
- India's S-400 missile defence system, activated for the first time in combat, intercepts multiple threats; also in play are the Akash surface-to-air missiles, Barak 8 air defence systems, anti-drone systems
- Pakistan targets Jammu; India claims successful interception of all missiles
- In all, Pakistan sends 300-400 Turkish-made Songar drones against 36 Indian sites. India retaliates with drone strikes on four Pak AD sites